Voix égales

Understanding electoral systems

Understand how votes become seats and discuss the tradeoffs between party representation, local ties and candidate choice.

DISCUSSION HANDOUT · 4 OCTOBER 2026

Five actual systems

Québec National Assembly · 2026 map: 127 constituencies	One vote, one person per constituency. The candidate with the most votes wins; no province-wide adjustment of party seats. [1, 2]
Australia House of Representatives	Rank every candidate. One person wins each constituency with a majority of valid votes, after transfers if needed; overall proportionality is not guaranteed. [3]
Germany Bundestag · since 2025	Two votes. Second votes determine eligible parties' seats; even a party candidate finishing first locally can receive no seat. [4]
Japan House of Representatives	Two votes: 289 local seats and 176 list seats across 11 regions. List seats add to local wins without compensating for them. [5]
Taiwan Legislative Yuan	73 territorial seats, 6 Indigenous seats and 34 national-list seats. List seats add to other seats without guaranteeing overall proportionality. [6]

Three reading notes

- The descriptions above concern actual systems. The 2022 case keeps votes unchanged; its mixed-system adaptations assume list votes and one provincial pool. It is not a forecast.
- Keeping the 125 constituencies of 2022, the scenarios have 125, 263, 201 or 183 seats. Compare percentages too: these sizes are teaching parameters, not a proposal to enlarge the Assembly.
- Australian scenario: with first choices unchanged, 46 seats are settled in the first round; 79 remain unknown without later preferences. Zero first-round PCQ wins does not mean zero final seats.

For discussion

1. What balance would you want between proportionality and a constituency connection?
2. What role should candidate choice, party choice and rankings each play?
3. Which assumptions should change before assessing a concrete proposal for Québec?

Official sources

[1] Élections Québec · voting system
[2] Élections Québec · 2026 map
[3] AEC · preferential voting
[4] Federal Returning Officer · Germany
[5] House of Representatives · Japan
[6] Constitution, Article 4 · Taiwan
2022 case · project calculations and assumptions